How the Orioles Lost Too Many 'Should-Have-Won' Games in 2025

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Abstract

As fans, we remember the 2025 Orioles season as a disappointment: a year filled with blown leads, frustrating losses, and games that felt like they should have been wins. But why? How did a talented roster fall short of the playoffs? There are likely many contributing factors, but this analysis focuses on one specific angle: how often the Orioles lost games they were expected to win. By identifying these "should-have-won" games, we can estimate how much those losses impacted their season, and what needs to improve going into 2026.

Research Question

How do we define a "should-have-won" game?

I began with a rule-based approach, defining these games as ones in which the Orioles:

- Scored 5+ runs
- Held a 3+ run lead
- Led after the 6th inning

However, I expanded the analysis to include a more objective metric: **win probability**. Using data from MLB's Stats API, any game in which the Orioles reached at least an 80% win probability at any point but still lost was also classified as a "should-have-won" game.

Pipeline

Using the MLB Stats API, I parsed all **2,430 regular season games** from 2025.

Key steps:

- Extracted play-by-play win probability data for each game
- Removed terminal values (0% and 100%) to avoid skewing results
- Created opportunity metrics:
  - Games reaching 8% win probability (80%, 85%, 90%, 95%)
  - Games leading after 6 innings
  - Games scoring 5+ runs
- Defined failures as losses after reaching those states
- Calculated **failure rates = failures / opportunities**

This allowed for a consistent comparison of how teams performed when put in strong winning positions.

League Context

To properly evaluate the Orioles, their performance must be compared to the rest of MLB.

Across these metrics, the Orioles were consistently below league average, though not always extreme outliers. However, teams that ranked poorly in these categories were rarely playoff teams.

The Orioles ranked in the top 10 worst teams in:

- 95% win probability loss rate
- 80% win probability loss rate
- Wasted offense (losses when scoring 5+ runs)

Figure 1 shows the distribution of 80% and 95% win probability failure rates across MLB, with the Orioles clearly positioned among the worst teams.

Notably, almost no playoff teams appeared in these bottom-10 groups, reinforcing that poor performance in these areas is strongly associated with missing the postseason.

Figure 1. Orioles vs League: 95% Win Probability Failure Rate

Results

The Orioles lost too many games from winning positions.

- **16 losses** after reaching 80% win probability (7th most)
- **3 losses** after reaching 95% win probability (4th most)
- **22 rule-based losses**, slightly above the league average of 20.5

We all remember a few of these games: late leads that slipped away, or matchups that felt over before suddenly turning the other way.

Figure 2 highlights how the Orioles compare to the league average in total "should-have-won" losses.

These are not just bad outcomes. They are the kinds of losses that quietly define a season.

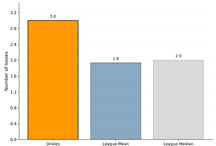

Figure 2. Orioles vs League: Total 95% Win Probability Losses

Opportunities

The Orioles also had fewer chances than average to be in strong positions:

- 23rd in games reaching 95% win probability
- 21st in games reaching 90%
- 24th in games scoring 5+ runs

Figure 3 shows that the Orioles ranked below the league mean in all high win probability opportunities.

The Orioles were not only worse at converting wins, but also worse at creating those opportunities in the first place.

Figure 3. Orioles vs League: Opportunities in Winning Game States

Analysis

The data aligns closely with the eye test.

The Orioles:

- Did not consistently put themselves in position to win
- Failed to close out games when they did

Watching it unfold over the course of the season, it often felt like the Orioles were either chasing games early or unable to fully close the door late.

This is likely tied to:

- Inconsistent starting pitching
- Bullpen instability
- Injuries (only 3 players avoided injury all season)

But the key takeaway is measurable:

- **95% WP games:** Orioles win rate = **95.2%**, league average = **97.2% (5th worst)**
- **3+ run leads:** Orioles = **87.5%**, league = **90.6% (7th worst)**
- **80% WP games:** Orioles = **82.8%**, league = **86.1% (7th worst)**
- **5+ run games:** Orioles = **74.6%**, league = **79.5% (7th worst)**

Across nearly every metric, the Orioles consistently ranked in the bottom quartile of MLB.

Figure 4 visualizes the relationship between opportunities and failure rates at 80% WP, showing that the Orioles struggled both to create and convert winning positions.

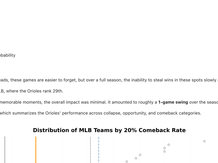

Figure 4. Opportunities vs Failure Rate Across MLB

Comebacks

I also analyzed the opposite scenario: comeback wins.

The Orioles ranked:

- Bottom 10 in nearly every comeback metric
- **29th (second worst)** in games where they fell to 20% win probability
- Orioles comeback rate at 20% WP: **7.6%**
- League average: **12.8%**

This indicates a lack of resilience when trailing. Unlike the blown leads, these games are easier to forget, but over a full season, the inability to steal wins in these spots slowly adds up.

Figure 5 shows the distribution of 20% comeback rates across MLB, where the Orioles rank 29th.

While the Orioles had 3 wins from 5% win probability, which were memorable moments, the overall impact was minimal. It amounted to roughly a **1-game swing** over the season. In contrast, blown games represent a much larger gap.

A full breakdown of all metrics and rankings is shown in **Figure 6**, which summarizes the Orioles' performance across collapse, opportunity, and comeback categories.

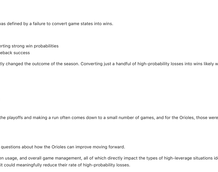

Figure 5. Distribution of 20% Comeback Rates Across MLB

Baltimore Orioles 2025: Full League Comparison Dashboard

Metric	Orioles	League Mean	League Median	Rank
rule_based_losses	22.0	20.5	20.0	9
wp_95_losses	3.0	1.9	2.0	4
wp_95_games	63.0	68.8	71.5	23
wp_95_losses	3.0	1.9	2.0	4
wp_95_losses	3.0	1.9	2.0	4
games_reached_80_wp	67.0	61.2	60.5	10
losses_after_80_wp	16.0	12.9	12.0	7
games_reached_85_wp	61.0	57.0	56.5	10
losses_after_85_wp	15.0	10.5	10.0	3
games_reached_90_wp	51.0	48.5	47.5	21
losses_after_90_wp	12.0	8.7	8.0	3
games_reached_95_wp	42.0	45.7	47.0	29
losses_after_95_wp	10.0	7.7	8.0	4
wp_95_win_rate	0.810	0.842	0.842	25
wp_90_win_rate	0.775	0.823	0.833	6
wp_85_win_rate	0.754	0.807	0.821	7
wp_80_win_rate	0.734	0.795	0.808	7
wp_95_loss_rate	0.048	0.032	0.033	7
wp_90_loss_rate	0.098	0.065	0.067	10
wp_85_loss_rate	0.123	0.086	0.089	10
wp_80_loss_rate	0.166	0.106	0.108	7
wasted_offense_loss_rate	0.254	0.181	0.167	7
wp_95_win_rate	0.174	0.158	0.158	5
wp_90_win_rate	0.149	0.098	0.089	12
wp_85_win_rate	0.128	0.077	0.067	11
wp_80_win_rate	0.098	0.058	0.050	7
games_tied_in_6_plus	38.0	41.2	39.5	19
games_tied_in_7_plus	30.0	34.5	32.5	5
games_tied_in_8_plus	20.0	25.4	24.5	3
comeback_wins	8.0	12.9	12.0	4
wp_20_comeback_wins	7.0	12.7	12.0	27
wp_15_comeback_wins	9.0	14.1	13.0	18
wp_10_comeback_wins	10.0	15.4	15.0	12
wp_5_comeback_wins	7.0	7.8	7.0	5
wp_20_comeback_rate	0.076	0.126	0.126	29
wp_15_comeback_rate	0.097	0.141	0.136	25
wp_10_comeback_rate	0.098	0.157	0.150	20
wp_5_comeback_rate	0.080	0.080	0.080	5
games_scored_plus_5	74.0	79.5	78.0	24
losses_after_5_plus	14.0	9.1	9.0	19
losses_after_5_plus_rate	0.189	0.116	0.115	20

Figure 6. Orioles 2025 Full Metric Summary vs League

Conclusion

The Orioles' 2025 season was not defined by a lack of talent; it was defined by a failure to convert game states into wins.

They struggled in two critical areas:

1. **Protecting leads** — ranking among the worst teams in converting strong win probabilities
2. **Recovering from deficits** — ranking near the bottom in comeback success

Even a modest improvement in these areas could have significantly changed the outcome of the season. Converting just a handful of high-probability losses into wins likely would have been enough to push the Orioles into playoff contention.

For 2026, the path forward is clear:

- Improve pitching stability to protect leads
- Increase offensive consistency to create more opportunities
- Develop late-game execution, both ahead and behind

Because in a 162-game season, the difference between missing the playoffs and making a run often comes down to a small number of games, and for the Orioles, those were the games they should have already won.

Implications for 2026

While this analysis focuses on 2025 outcomes, it naturally raises questions about how the Orioles can improve moving forward.

A new manager may influence late-game decision-making, bullpen usage, and overall game management, all of which directly impact the types of high-leverage situations identified in this analysis. If the Orioles can improve in these areas, particularly in protecting leads and optimizing pitching changes, it could meaningfully reduce their rate of high-probability losses.

However, managerial changes alone are unlikely to fully resolve the issue. The data suggests that both roster-level improvements (particularly in pitching depth and consistency) and strategic execution will be necessary to increase opportunities and convert them into wins.

The Orioles have already made notable roster additions, including Pete Alonso, Taylor Ward, and Ryan Helsley. While these moves may improve specific areas, particularly offensive production and late-inning relief, the results from 2025 suggest that isolated upgrades are unlikely to fully address the broader issue. The team's challenges were systemic, affecting both opportunity creation and game-state conversion.

Ultimately, the Orioles' path forward is measurable. If they can move closer to league average in both opportunity creation and game-state conversion, the impact would likely be reflected directly in the standings.

All charts and full data outputs are included in the Appendix and supplementary materials.

Appendix

A1. Data Sources

All data was obtained using the MLB Stats API, including:

- Game schedules and results
- Play-by-play data
- Win probability data for each event

A2. Definitions

Win Probability (WP)
The probability that a team will win the game at a given moment, based on game state.

Should-Have-Won Game
A loss in which a team reached a specified win probability threshold (80%, 85%, 90%, or 95%) or met rule-based criteria (5+ runs, 3+ run lead, or leading after 6 innings).

Opportunity Metrics
The number of games in which a team reached a specific game state (for example, 90% WP or leading after 6 innings).

Failure Rate
Failures divided by opportunities:

```
failure rate = losses / opportunities
```

Comeback Rate
Wins divided by opportunities when trailing:

```
comeback rate = comeback wins / games in trailing state
```

A3. Methodology Notes

- Terminal win probabilities (0% and 100%) were excluded to avoid bias
- All metrics were calculated at the team level
- League averages were computed as the **mean of team-level rates**, ensuring equal weighting across teams
- Only regular season games (162 per team) were included

A4. Limitations

- Win probability does not capture all contextual factors (for example, bullpen strength or matchups)
- Some late-game states may be disproportionately impactful
- Results are descriptive and do not establish causation

Supplementary Materials

All data outputs, processed datasets, and visualizations generated for this analysis are included as supplementary materials. Due to platform limitations, the full `charts/` directory (containing all figures) is not embedded directly within this notebook.

The supplementary materials include:

- The full team-level dataset (`all3_2025_should_have_won_team_summary.csv`)
- Game-level logs for all 2,430 MLB games analyzed
- Orioles vs. league comparison tables
- Over 40 generated visualizations covering collapse metrics, opportunity metrics, and comeback performance

The `charts/` directory contains all figures referenced in this article, including:

- Win probability failure rate comparisons
- Opportunity vs. conversion scatter plots
- League-wide rankings and distributions
- Comeback win and rate analyses
- A full Orioles performance dashboard

All materials are reproducible using the provided Python scripts. For full access to the visual outputs, please download the repository and accompanying files where the `charts/` folder is included in its entirety.

Supplementary materials (all scripts and figures): Download orioles-2025-win-prob-analysis.zip